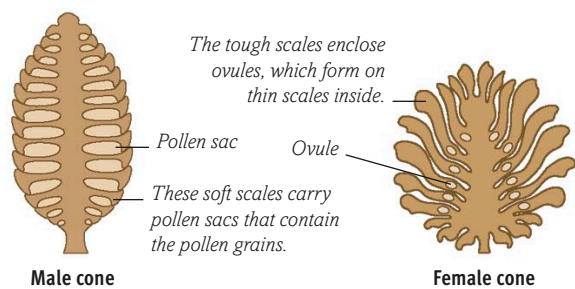


What is a conifer cone?

A conifer cone contains the male or female cells of conifer trees. In nonflowering plants such as pine trees, cones are the equivalent of a flower. The seeds of conifers are not contained in fruits but develop between the scales of the pollinated female cones. The scales protect the seeds until they are fully developed, then open up to release their seeds.

Closed cone scales ➤ The female cones contain ovules (clusters of female cells) that will develop into seeds if they are fertilized by pollen. Blown on the wind, the pollen grains are small enough to slip between the scales and enter each ovule.

Male and female cones



Most conifer trees have separate male and female cones. The long, soft male cones produce pollen, while the woody female cones contain ovules that will become seeds when fertilized. The pollen grains are tiny, like dust, so they are easily blown on the wind.



Closed Austrian pine cone